

A Writing Guide for Engineers

Tips on Doc Structure,
Presentation, & Language

Jim Foley
Fall 2022



Topics

- Foundations
- Structure
- Presentation
- Language

Foundations

- Reading
- Writing
- Audience

What makes writing good?

We'll start with bare metal:

How do humans read?

How People Read

Fast words,
slow words

Visual
recognition

"use"

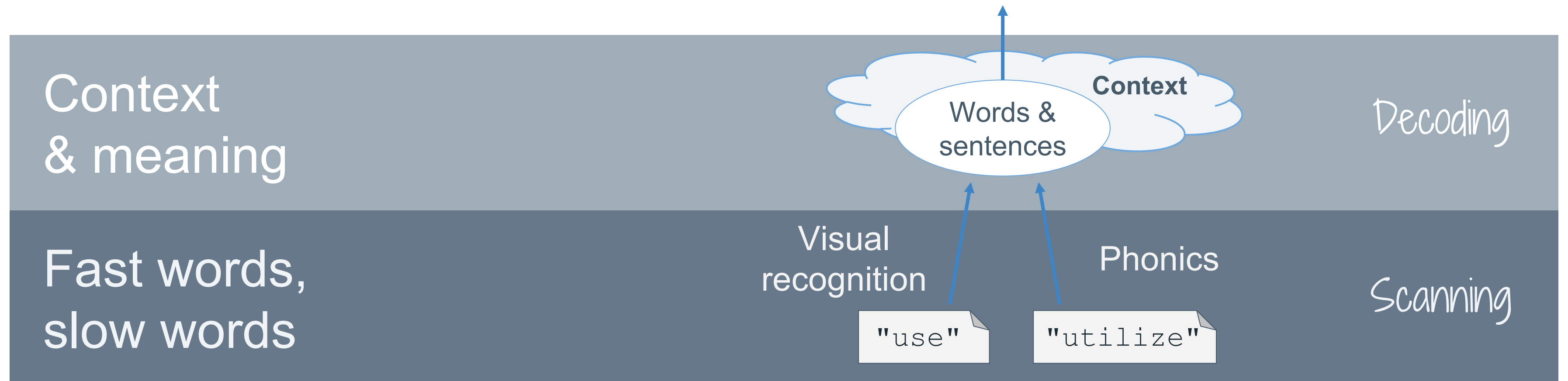
Phonics

"utilize"

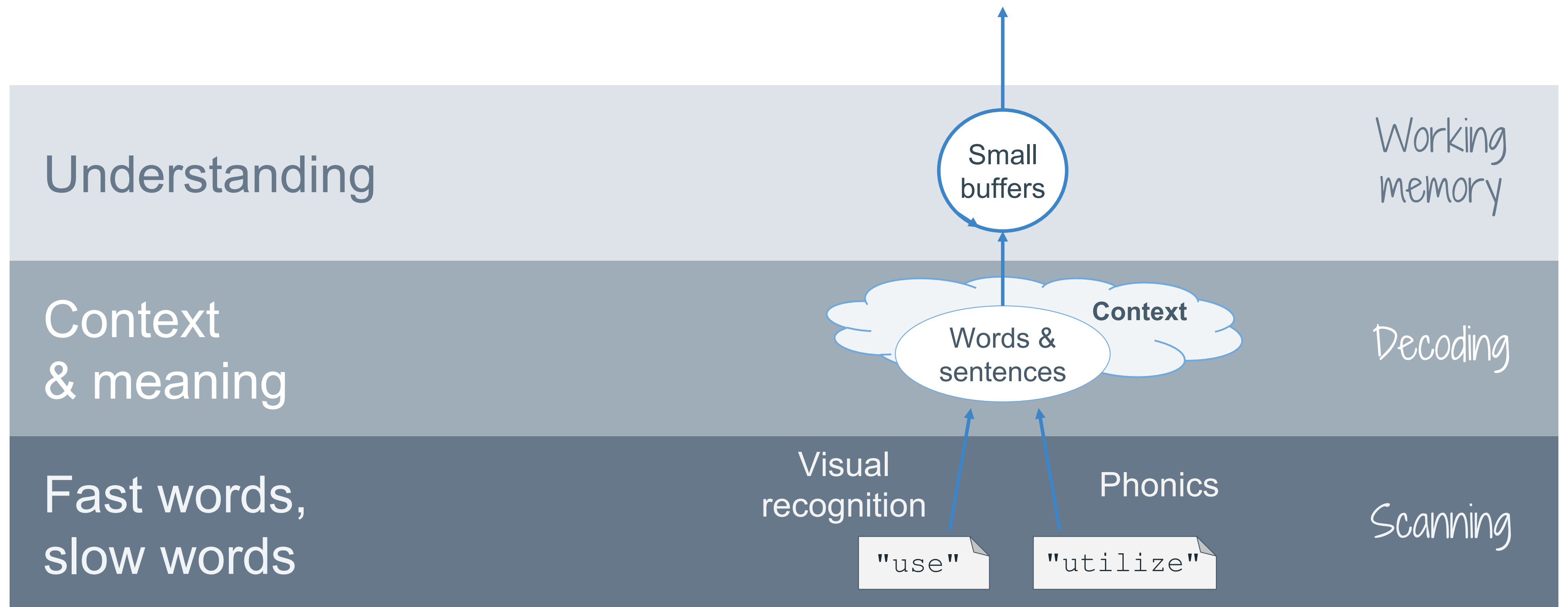
Scanning



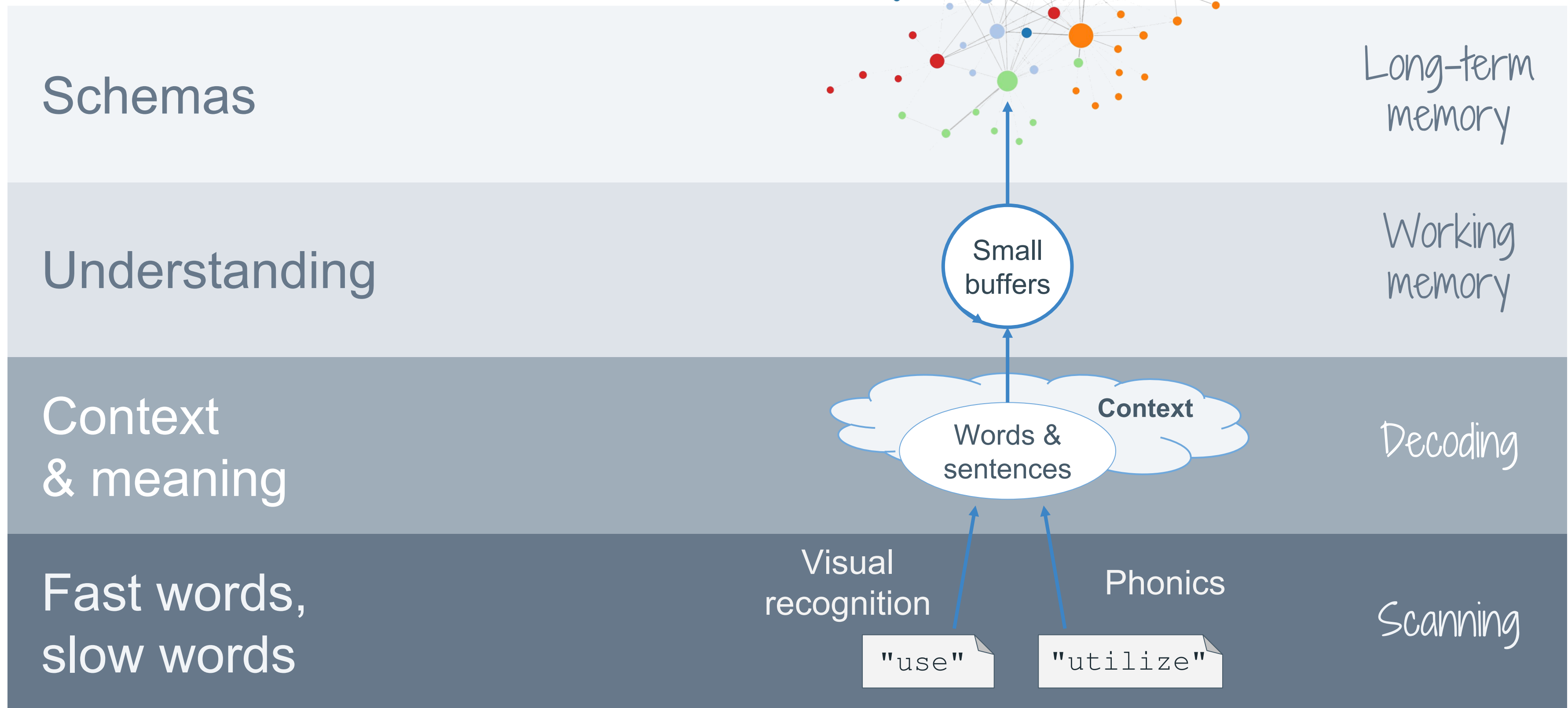
How People Read



How People Read



How People Read



What Makes Writing Good

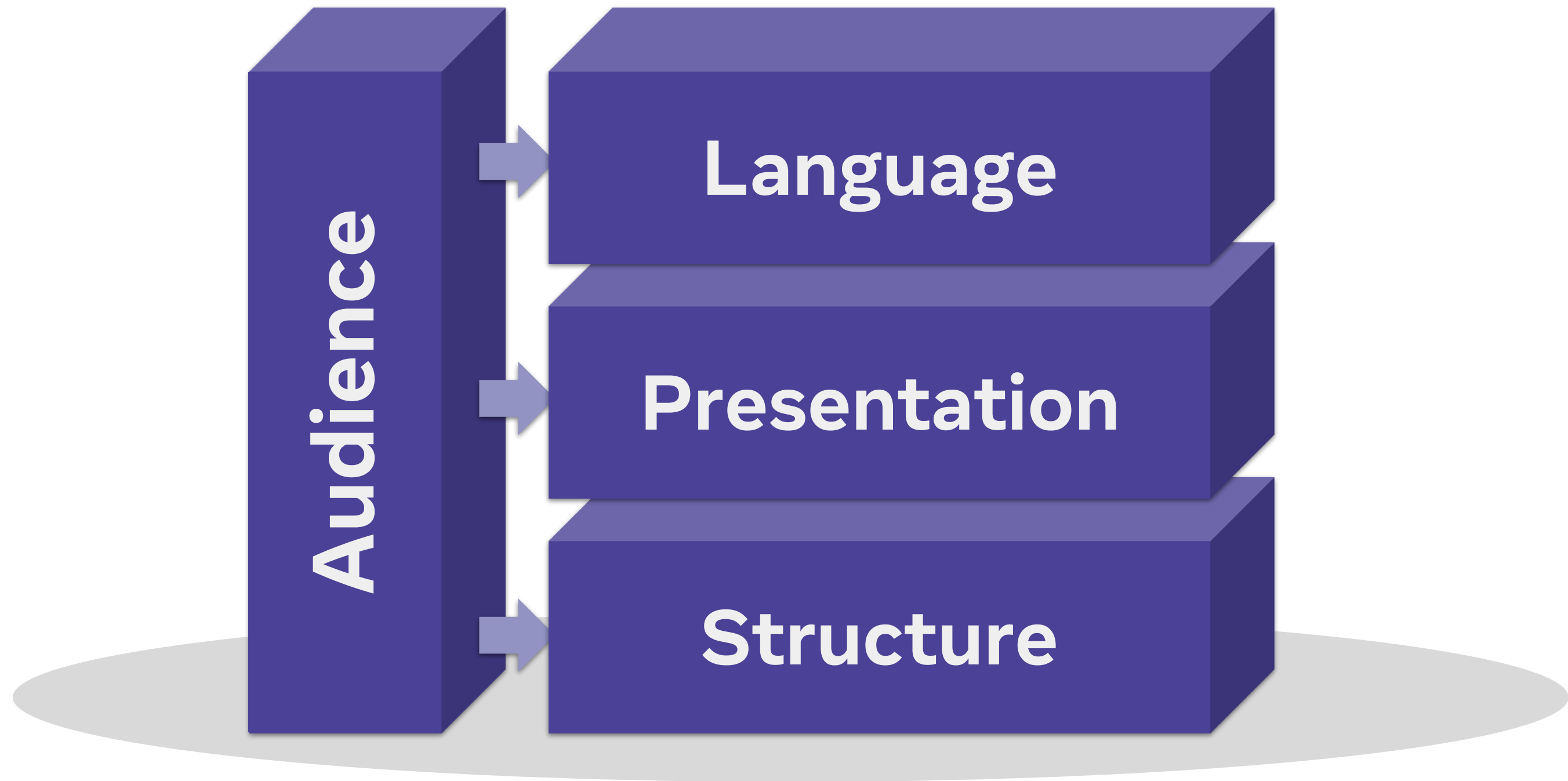
proper spelling & grammar

What Makes Writing Good

1. Information
2. chunked & sequenced
3. with context & insights
4. in a visually-helpful presentation
5. ...with proper spelling & grammar

Audience.

The curse of knowledge 🤯



Think About Your Audience

Janet, you just
don't understand me...

But I do, Brad! I've considered
your role, knowledge, use-case,
time-frame, and how you
got to this doc.



Structure

- Modular Design
- Maintenance & Discovery
- Chunk & Sequence
- A Writing Algorithm

Well-designed information
is easy to find, read,
write, & maintain.

Flow from General to Specific

Using Zapvac Like a Pro

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Important Concepts You Should Know

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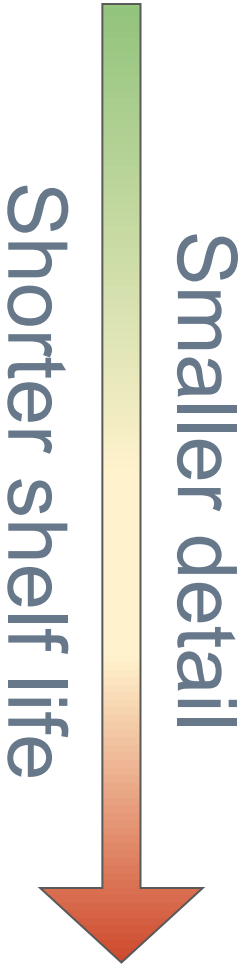
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How to Set Up Your Zapvac

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Separate the 3 Information Types

Concepts

Instructions

Reference

Using Zapvac Like a Pro

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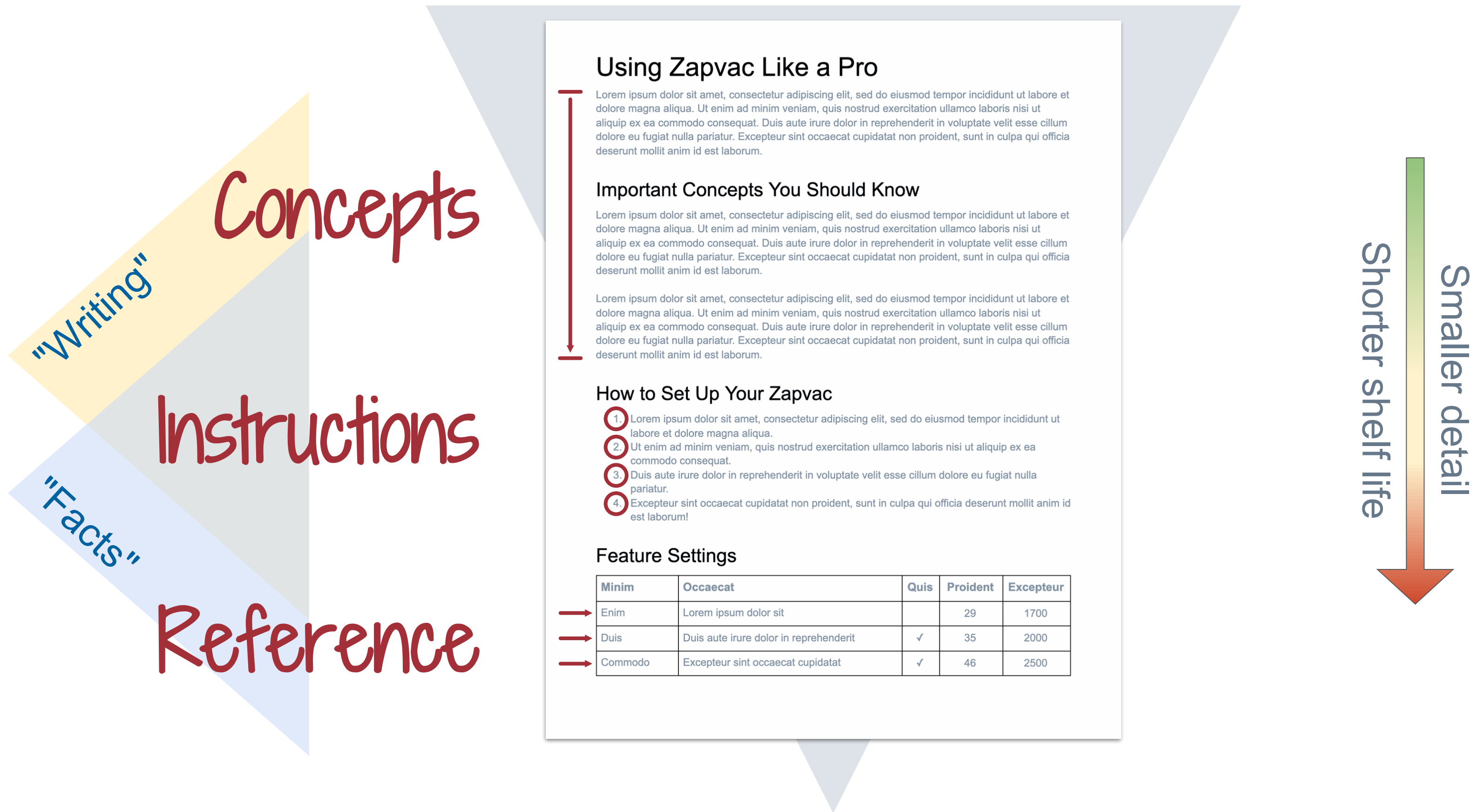
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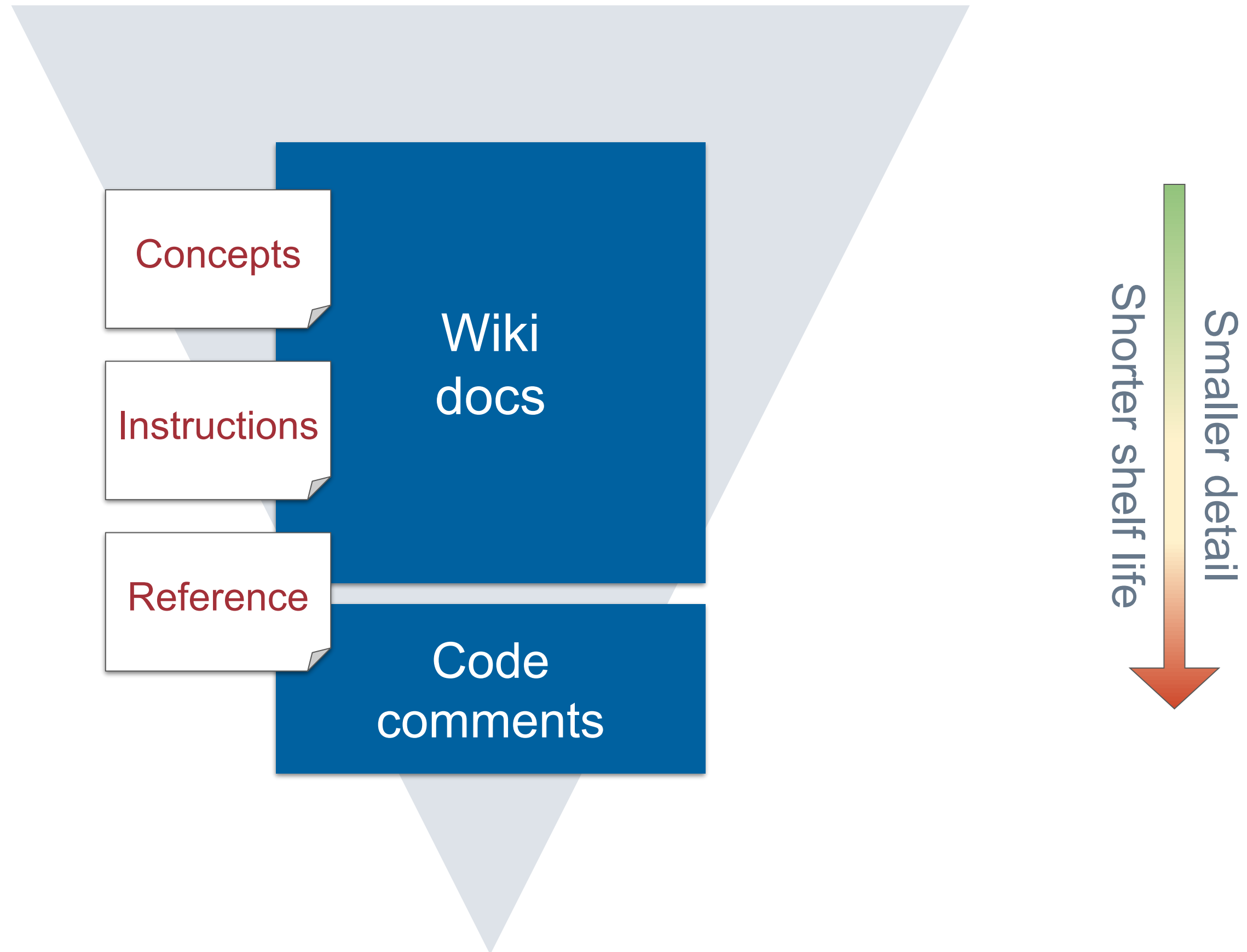
Shorter shelf life

Smaller detail

Separate the 3 Information Types



Separate the 3 Information Types



Avoid Repetition

"x = 7"

Using Zapvac Like a Pro

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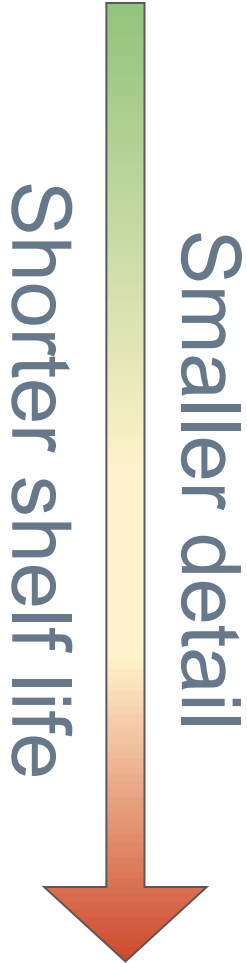
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How to Set Up Your Zapvac

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Avoid Repetition

"X is the..."

"Set x & y."

"x = 7"

Using Zapvac Like a Pro

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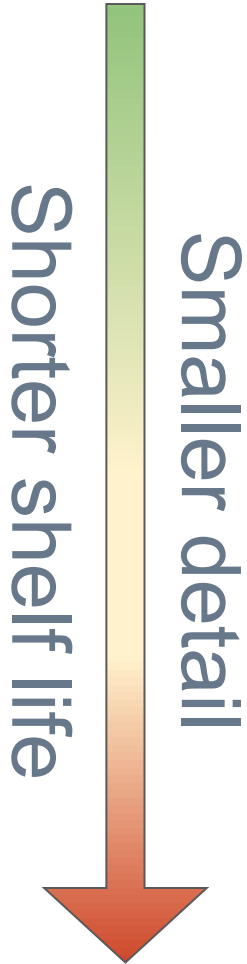
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Modular Docs

1. Flow from general to specific

2. Separate the 3 information types:

- Concepts
- Instructions
- Reference

3. Avoid repetition

Using Zapvac Like a Pro

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*How about doc
maintenance?
Or how readers will
find a fix for a
critical bug at 3am?*



Plan for Maintenance

- ☑ Use modular design
- ☑ Plan for updates & growth
 - ☐ Text & tables
 - ☐ Images
 - ☐ Sample code
 - ☐ Page style



Plan for Maintenance

- ☑ Use modular design
- ☑ Plan for updates & growth
 - ☑ Text & tables
 - ☑ Images
 - ☑ Sample code
 - ☑ Page style



Plan for Discovery

- ☑ Invest in navigation
- ☑ Optimize for search
- ☑ Show reading paths
- ☑ FAQ



Typical Structure

- Introduction
- Body
 - Main ideas
 - Expand or implement
 - Subtopics
 - Installation, tutorials
 - Advanced details, reference

Using Zapvac Like a Pro

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Typical Structure +

- Introduction
- Body
 - Main ideas
 - Expand or implement
 - Subtopics
 - Installation, tutorials
 - Advanced details, reference
- Ending *(optional)*
 - Summary, What’s Next
 - POCs, Related Resources
- Appendix *(optional)*
 - Side concepts, reference, troubleshooting, FAQ

Using Zapvac Like a Pro

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Appendix: The History of Zapvac

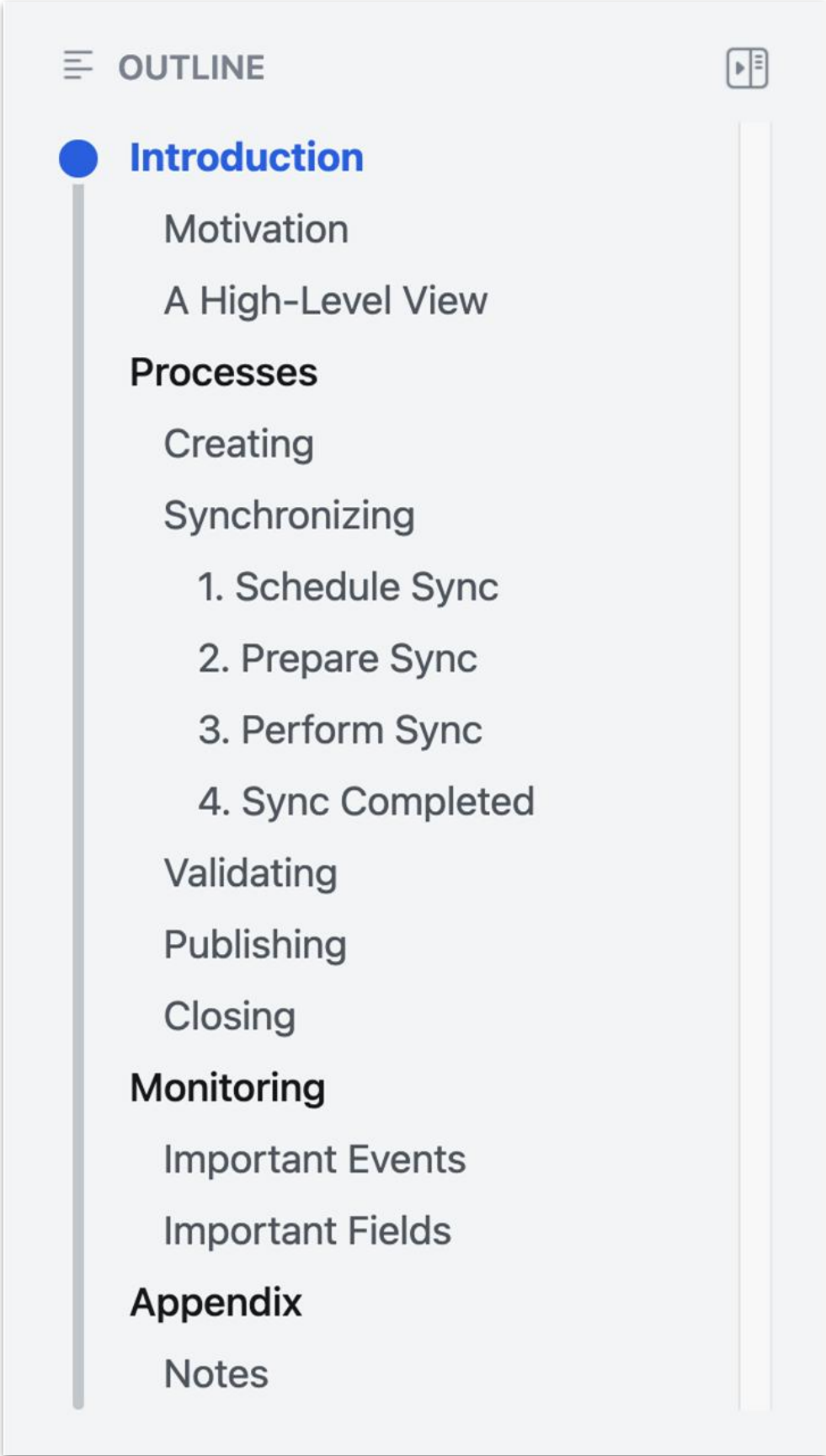
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Chunk & Sequence

- Small, logical chunks (*< 7 items*)
- Meaningful sequence
- Multiple levels

Chunk & Sequence

- Small, logical chunks (*< 7 items*)
- Meaningful sequence
- Multiple levels

A sidebar table of contents with a light gray background. At the top left is a hamburger menu icon and the word 'OUTLINE'. At the top right is a document icon. A vertical blue line on the left side of the list indicates the current position, which is at the 'Introduction' section.

OUTLINE	
●	Introduction
	Motivation
	A High-Level View
	Processes
	Creating
	Synchronizing
	1. Schedule Sync
	2. Prepare Sync
	3. Perform Sync
	4. Sync Completed
	Validating
	Publishing
	Closing
	Monitoring
	Important Events
	Important Fields
	Appendix
	Notes

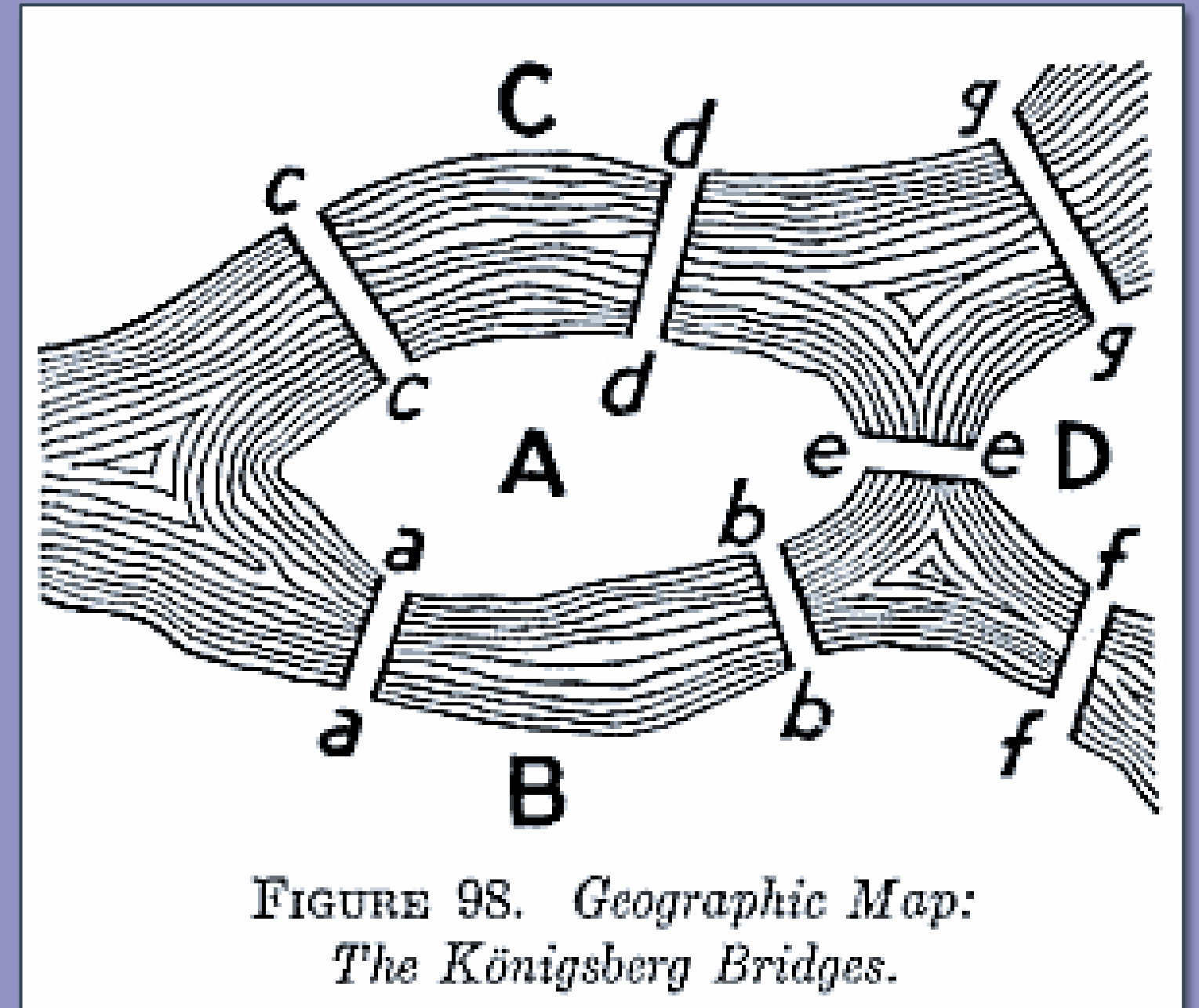
A Structure Algorithm

1. List the topics
2. Chunk & sequence
3. Solve overlaps & dependencies

A Structure Algorithm

1. List the topics
2. Chunk & sequence
3. Solve overlaps & dependencies

Fix path problems by using levels.



A Writing Algorithm

1. Structure
2. Draft
3. Review

Try to separate these processes.



Example: 20-Page Wiki

Challenge: Multiple audiences at multiple depths

Zapvac

This site documents the Zapvac framework for developers. It's designed as the shortest possible reading experience for you, whether you want:

- Just an overview
- Only the quick basics needed to create a minimal instance
- In-depth reference material for building a complex instance

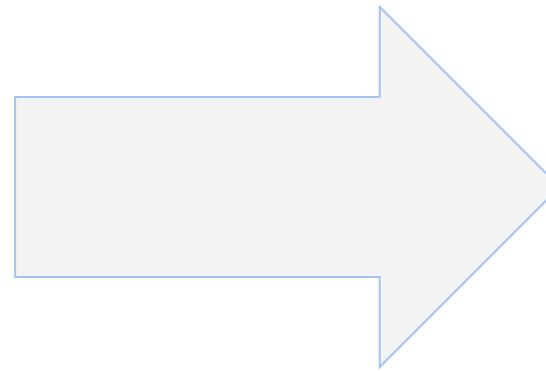
It helps if you already know a little about the subject, but it's not required.

Example: 20-Page Wiki

- Concepts
- Tutorial
- Key Topics
- Reference

Example: 20-Page Wiki

- Concepts
- Tutorial
- Key Topics
- Reference



Concepts

Architecture

Flow

Error Handling

Tutorial

1. Configuration

2. Define Features

3. Integrate into Application

4. (Advanced) Customizing

5. (Advanced) Scripting

Key Topics

Basic Features

Advanced Features

Performance

Reference

Functions

Parameter List

Error Codes

Examples

Sample Script

Example: 20-Page Wiki

- Concepts
- Tutorial
- Key Topics
- Reference

Concepts

Architecture
Flow
Error Handling

Tutorial

1. Configuration
2. Define Features
3. Integrate into Application
4. (Advanced) Customizing
5. (Advanced) Scripting

Key Topics

Basic Features
Advanced Features
Performance

Reference

Functions
Parameter List
Error Codes
Examples
Sample Script

Presentation

- Introductions
- Definitions
- Visible Structure
- Images, Tables, & Samples

Give your readers an
unfair advantage.

Page Introduction

Definition

This page is an overview of Zapvac, a tool we use to catch bugs.

Topic Introduction

Introduce Your Page

This page is an overview of Zapvac, a tool we use to catch bugs.

~

Easy templates:

- This is a type of doc on topic for audience / use-case.
- This is a type of doc on topic, which is definition.
- This is a type of doc for audience who use-case.

Introduce Your Page

This tutorial on cleaning your Zapvac takes about an hour, and requires a screwdriver. It's intended for engineers who have read the [Zapvac overview](#).

Introduce Your Topics

Zaptrack was designed to provide **clear**, **fast**, and **regular** feedback to developers about their code changes with **low computational expense**.

Introduce Your Topics

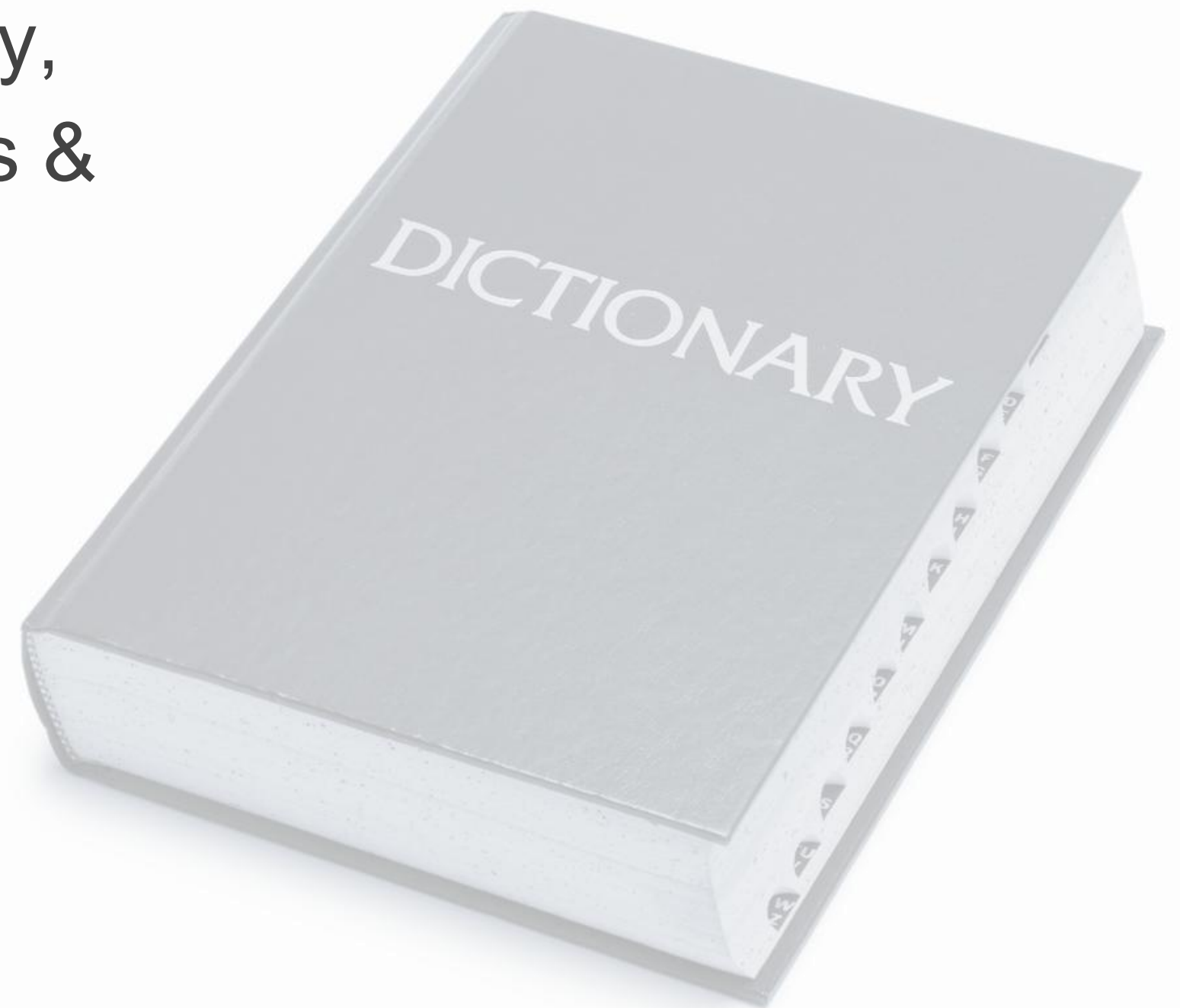
Zaptrack was designed to provide **clear**, **fast**, and **regular** feedback to developers about their code changes with **low energy consumption**.

- The feedback must be **clear** so that...
- The feedback must be **fast** because...
- The feedback must be **regular** because..

Zaptrack strives for **low computational expense** because...

Define Your Terms

1. **Say what it is** (use prototype or category)
2. **Differentiate** from others in the category
3. **Optionally expand** with purpose, history, principles, features, examples, strengths & weaknesses, etc.



Define Your Terms

1. Say what it is

2. Differentiate

3. Optionally expand

- ✓ *Source control* is a set of tools and strategies for managing source code.
- ✓ A *commit* is a set of saved changes.
- ✓ *Zaptrack* is our continuous integration system that builds, tests, and lands your changes. It is a highly modular system that...

Show Your Structure

- Titles & section headings
- Paragraphs
- Lists
- Tables

Using Zapvac Like a Pro

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Important Concepts

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Why Zapvac Is Awesome

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How to Set Up Your Zapvac

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Feature Settings

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Appendix: The History of Zapvac

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OUTLINE

● Important Concepts

Why Zapvac Is Awesome

How to Set Up Your Zapvac

Feature Settings

Appendix: The History of Zap...

Other Document Elements

- Diagrams and charts
- Screenshots
- Tables
- Code samples
- Hyperlinks

Diagrams

Proprietary Facebook images removed. 😊

Charts

Proprietary Facebook images removed. 😊

Screenshots

Proprietary Facebook images removed. 😊

Tables

Proprietary Facebook images removed. 😊

Code Samples

Proprietary Facebook images removed. 😊

Hyperlinks

- We ran into some [problems](#).
- We ran into some problems ([post](#)).
- We ran into some problems ([list](#)).
- We ran into some problems ([example](#)).

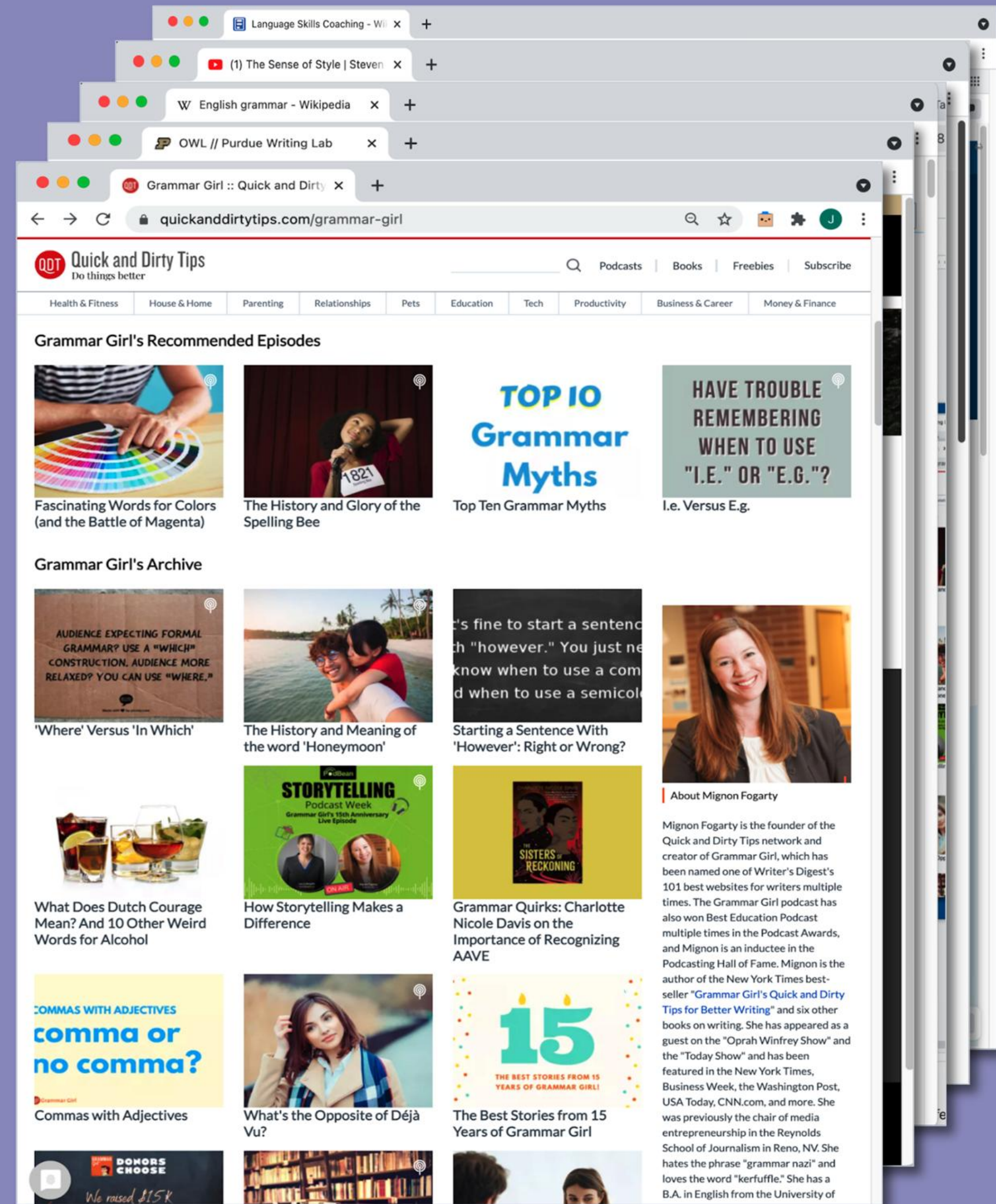
Language

- Use Informal Style
- Avoid Comm Breakdowns
- Use Active Language
- Make Connections

Talk to your audience.

What About Grammar?

- ✓ If in doubt, write around it
- ✓ Learn a few grammar tricks a year
- ✓ Train your ear like a neural net



Use Informal Writing Style

- ✓ Personal words (you, we)
- ✓ Contractions (isn't)
- ✓ Less-formal words

Avoid Communication Breakdowns

- Ambiguity - the unrecoverable error
- Jargon (undefined terms)
- Long sentences, phrases, or word stacks



Use Active Language

- Short, familiar words & short sentences
- Direct, active sentences
- Be concise



Good start. Needs more gibberish.

Use Active Language

- Short, familiar words & short sentences
- Direct, active sentences
- Be concise

run
window
set interface
parameter
object
compare
type memory

which
on
as to
for that
of the

Use Active Language

- Short, familiar words & short sentences
- Direct, active sentences
- Be concise

Are you ~~even~~ being serious right now?

Are you being serious ~~right~~ now?

Are you being serious ~~now~~?

Are you ~~being~~ serious?

~~Are you~~ serious?

~~Seriously?~~

Really?

Make Connections

- Use connecting words: *first, and, or, if, but, also, then, so, with, always, never, since, because, before, instead, however, therefore...*
- Use story: goals, problems, themes, solutions, lessons



What If I'm a Terrible Writer?

What If I'm a Terrible Writer?

Remember what makes writing good.

What If I'm a Terrible Writer?

Remember what makes writing good.

1. Information
2. chunked & sequenced
3. with context & insights
4. in a visually-helpful presentation
5. ...with ~~proper spelling & grammar~~
simple, direct, active language

Takeaways

- Foundations
- Structure
- Presentation
- Language

Takeaways

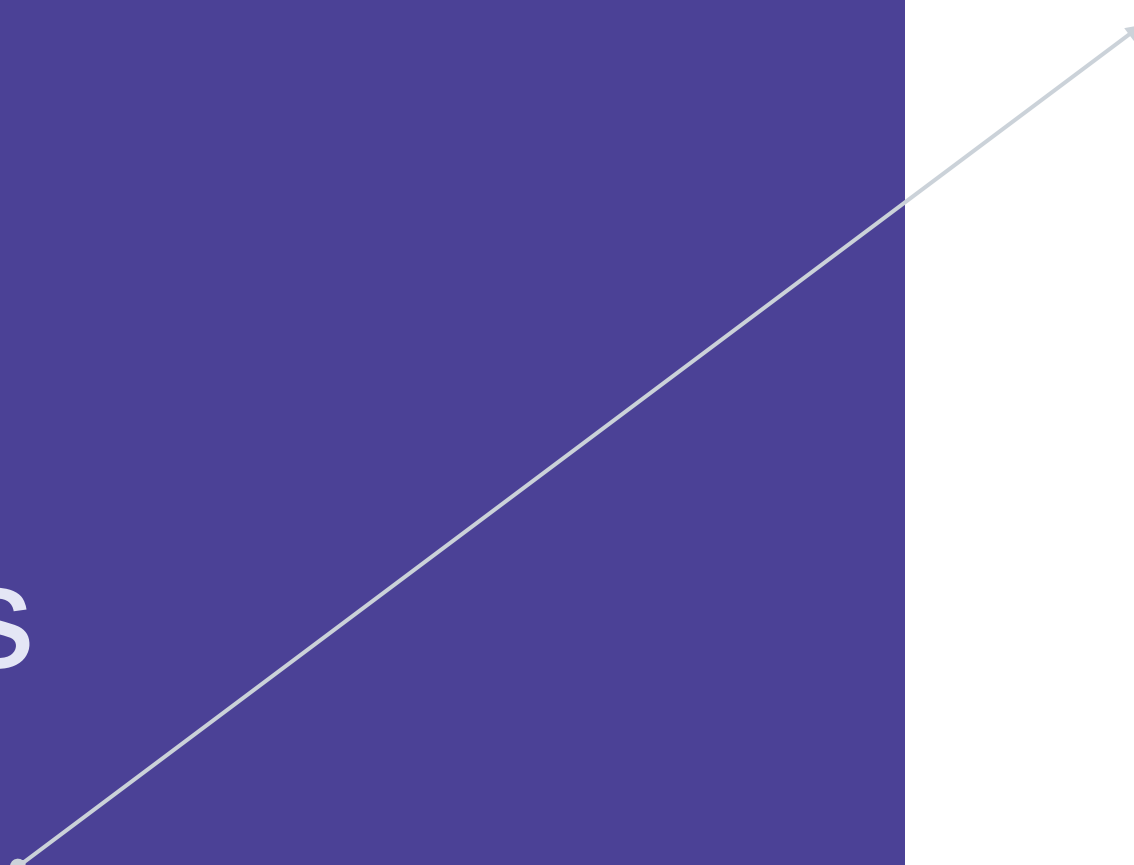
→ Foundations

→ Structure

→ Presentation

→ Language

→ Audience

A thin grey line with an arrowhead at the end connects a small dot next to the word 'Foundations' to a circle containing a right-pointing arrow, which is positioned next to the word 'Audience'.

Takeaways

- Foundations
- Structure
- Presentation
- Language

- Audience
- Modular Design
- Maintenance & Discovery
- Chunk & Sequence

Takeaways

→ Foundations

→ Structure

→ Presentation

→ Language

→ Audience

→ Modular Design

→ Maintenance & Discovery

→ Chunk & Sequence

→ Introductions

→ Definitions

→ Visible Structure

→ Images, Tables, & Samples

Takeaways

→ Foundations

→ Structure

→ Presentation

→ Language

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→ Modular Design

→ Maintenance & Discovery

→ Chunk & Sequence

→ Introductions

→ Definitions

→ Visible Structure

→ Images, Tables, & Samples

→ Informal Style

→ Avoid Comm Breakdowns

→ Simple, Direct, Active

→ Connections

Questions?

